

GUIDED PATHS IN LOW-D: CONTROLLED GENERATION VIA TRAJECTORY GUIDANCE IN LOW-DIMENSIONAL DIFFUSION MODELS

Anonymous authors

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ABSTRACT

This paper introduces a novel approach for controlled generation in low-dimensional diffusion models using trajectory guidance. While diffusion models have shown remarkable success in generating high-quality samples, controlling the generation process remains challenging, especially in low-dimensional spaces where precise control is crucial. We address this challenge by incorporating predefined guidance paths and a tunable guidance strength parameter into the diffusion process. Our method allows for fine-grained control over the generated samples while balancing fidelity to the original data distribution. We evaluate our approach on various 2D datasets using both linear and circular guidance paths, demonstrating its effectiveness in steering the generation process. Our experiments reveal a trade-off between path adherence and distribution matching, with stronger guidance leading to better path following but greater deviation from the original distribution. This work provides insights into controlled generation in low-dimensional spaces and opens up new possibilities for applications in areas such as trajectory planning and parameter space exploration.

1 INTRODUCTION

Diffusion models have emerged as a powerful class of generative models, achieving state-of-the-art results in various domains such as image generation, audio synthesis, and molecular design Yang et al. (2023). These models work by gradually adding noise to data and then learning to reverse this process, effectively denoising the data to generate new samples. While diffusion models have shown remarkable success in generating high-quality samples, controlling the generation process remains a significant challenge, particularly in low-dimensional spaces where precise control is often crucial.

In this paper, we address the problem of controlled generation in low-dimensional diffusion models. Our goal is to develop a method that allows for fine-grained control over the generation process while maintaining the benefits of diffusion models, such as stable training and high-quality sample generation. This is particularly relevant for applications in scientific simulations, trajectory planning, and parameter space exploration, where low-dimensional representations are common and precise control over the generated samples is essential.

The main challenges in achieving controlled generation in low-dimensional diffusion models are:

1. Balancing control and data fidelity: Steering the generation process towards a desired outcome while maintaining the characteristics of the original data distribution.
2. Designing an effective guidance mechanism: Creating a simple yet powerful method for guiding the diffusion process in low-dimensional spaces.
3. Quantifying and visualizing the trade-offs: Developing metrics and visualizations to understand the impact of guidance on sample quality and distribution matching.

To address these challenges, we propose a novel approach that incorporates predefined guidance paths and a tunable guidance strength parameter into the diffusion process. Our method allows for explicit control over the generation trajectory while providing a mechanism to balance this control with fidelity to the original data distribution.

Our main contributions are:

- A novel guidance mechanism for low-dimensional diffusion models that allows for fine-grained control over the generation process.
- A comprehensive analysis of the trade-offs between path adherence and distribution matching in guided diffusion.
- Experimental validation of our approach on various 2D datasets using both linear and circular guidance paths.
- Insights into the behavior of guided diffusion in low-dimensional spaces, which may inform future developments in both low and high-dimensional domains.

We evaluate our method on four synthetic 2D datasets: circle, dino, line, and moons. Our experiments demonstrate the effectiveness of our approach in steering the generation process along both linear and non-linear paths. We show that by adjusting the guidance strength, we can control the balance between following the predefined path and maintaining the characteristics of the original data distribution.

Our results reveal a clear trade-off between path adherence and distribution matching, with stronger guidance leading to better path following but greater deviation from the original distribution. This trade-off is quantified using metrics such as Kullback-Leibler (KL) divergence and mean squared error (MSE) from the guidance path.

The insights gained from this work open up new possibilities for controlled generation in low-dimensional spaces and provide a foundation for future research in guided generative modeling. Potential future directions include extending the approach to higher-dimensional data, developing adaptive guidance mechanisms, and exploring applications in specific domains such as robotics or scientific computing.

2 RELATED WORK

Our work on guided generation in low-dimensional diffusion models builds upon and extends several areas of research in generative modeling and controlled generation.

2.1 GUIDED DIFFUSION METHODS

Recent advancements in diffusion models have led to various approaches for guided generation, primarily focusing on high-dimensional data such as images. Ho et al. (2020) introduced the Denoising Diffusion Probabilistic Models (DDPM) framework, which forms the basis for many subsequent guided diffusion methods. While these methods have shown remarkable success in high-dimensional domains, they often rely on complex architectures and large-scale training, which may not be necessary or directly applicable to low-dimensional data.

In contrast to these approaches, our method focuses on simple, interpretable guidance in low-dimensional spaces. We introduce a guidance path and strength parameter that can be easily visualized and understood, making it particularly suitable for applications where precise control and interpretability are crucial.

2.2 CONTROLLED GENERATION IN OTHER GENERATIVE MODELS

Controlled generation has been explored in other generative frameworks such as Generative Adversarial Networks (GANs) Goodfellow et al. (2014) and Variational Autoencoders (VAEs) Kingma & Welling (2014). These approaches often involve conditioning the generation process on specific attributes or using latent space manipulations to achieve desired outcomes.

While these methods offer valuable insights into controlled generation, they face challenges such as mode collapse (in GANs) or blurry outputs (in VAEs) that diffusion models aim to address. Our approach leverages the stability and high-quality sample generation of diffusion models while providing fine-grained control over the generation process.

2.3 LOW-DIMENSIONAL DIFFUSION MODELS

Most research in diffusion models has focused on high-dimensional data, particularly images. However, there is growing interest in applying diffusion models to low-dimensional data. For instance, Kotelnikov et al. (2022) proposed TabDDPM, a diffusion-based approach for modeling tabular data.

Our work extends this line of research by introducing a novel guidance mechanism specifically designed for low-dimensional spaces. Unlike TabDDPM, which focuses on general modeling of tabular data, our method provides explicit control over the generation trajectory, opening up new possibilities for applications such as trajectory planning or parameter space exploration.

By focusing on low-dimensional data and providing a simple yet effective guidance mechanism, our work bridges the gap between guided diffusion methods and low-dimensional data modeling. It offers insights into the fundamental behavior of guided diffusion processes, which may inform future developments in both low and high-dimensional domains.

3 BACKGROUND

Diffusion models have emerged as a powerful class of generative models, achieving state-of-the-art results in various domains Yang et al. (2023). The core idea behind diffusion models, introduced by ?, is to define a forward diffusion process that gradually adds Gaussian noise to the data, and then learn a reverse diffusion process that removes this noise step by step. This reverse process is typically parameterized by a neural network and trained to predict the noise at each step, allowing for high-quality sample generation.

The Denoising Diffusion Probabilistic Models (DDPM) framework, proposed by Ho et al. (2020), has become a cornerstone in the field. DDPMs define a fixed Markov chain for the forward process and use a neural network to learn the reverse process. This approach has shown remarkable success in generating high-quality samples while maintaining stable training dynamics.

Recent work has explored guided diffusion, where the generation process is steered towards desired outcomes. However, most existing approaches focus on high-dimensional data like images, leaving the potential of guided diffusion for low-dimensional data largely unexplored.

3.1 PROBLEM SETTING

In this work, we focus on controlled generation in low-dimensional diffusion models. We consider a dataset $\mathcal{D} = \{x_i\}_{i=1}^N$ where $x_i \in \mathbb{R}^d$ and d is small (in our case, $d = 2$). Our goal is to train a diffusion model that can generate samples from the data distribution while following a predefined path in the low-dimensional space.

We define a guidance path $P : [0, 1] \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^d$ that specifies the desired trajectory for the generated samples. In our experiments, we consider both linear and circular paths:

- Linear path: $P_{\text{linear}}(t) = (1 - t)(-1, -1) + t(1, 1)$
- Circular path: $P_{\text{circular}}(t) = (\cos(2\pi t), \sin(2\pi t))$

We introduce a guidance strength parameter $\lambda \in [0, 1]$ that controls the trade-off between following the predefined path and maintaining the characteristics of the original data distribution. Our objective is to develop a method that can effectively balance these two goals, allowing for controlled generation while preserving the quality and diversity of the generated samples.

This problem setting presents unique challenges and opportunities in the context of low-dimensional diffusion models, as the reduced dimensionality allows for more direct control and visualization of the generation process. Unlike previous work on guided diffusion, which often focuses on complex, high-dimensional data, our approach aims to provide precise control in low-dimensional spaces where interpretability and fine-grained control are crucial.

4 METHOD

Building upon the DDPM framework introduced in Section 3, we propose a novel approach for guided diffusion in low-dimensional spaces. Our method introduces a guidance mechanism that steers the generation process towards predefined paths while maintaining the benefits of diffusion models.

4.1 GUIDED DIFFUSION PROCESS

We modify the standard diffusion process to incorporate guidance. Given a predefined path $P : [0, 1] \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^d$ and a guidance strength parameter $\lambda \in [0, 1]$, we define the guided denoising step as:

$$x_{t-1} = \mu_\theta(x_t, t) + \lambda(P(1 - t/T) - x_t) + \sigma_t z \quad (1)$$

where μ_θ is the learned denoising model, T is the total number of diffusion steps, σ_t is the noise scale at step t , and $z \sim \mathcal{N}(0, I)$.

The guidance term $\lambda(P(1 - t/T) - x_t)$ pulls the sample towards the target point on the path. The strength parameter λ controls the trade-off between following the path and maintaining the learned distribution.

4.2 PATH DEFINITIONS

We consider two types of guidance paths:

- Linear path: $P_{\text{linear}}(t) = (1 - t)(-1, -1) + t(1, 1)$
- Circular path: $P_{\text{circular}}(t) = (\cos(2\pi t), \sin(2\pi t))$

These paths allow us to evaluate our method’s effectiveness in guiding the generation process along both linear and non-linear trajectories.

4.3 MODEL ARCHITECTURE

We use a simple MLP architecture for the denoising model μ_θ :

- Sinusoidal embeddings for time and input (dimension 128)
- 3 hidden layers with 256 units each and ReLU activations
- Residual connections between hidden layers
- Final linear layer to output the denoised sample

This architecture is designed to capture high-frequency patterns effectively in low-dimensional data.

4.4 TRAINING AND SAMPLING

We train the model using the standard DDPM objective:

$$\mathcal{L} = \mathbb{E}_{t, x_0, \epsilon} [\|\epsilon - \epsilon_\theta(x_t, t)\|^2] \quad (2)$$

where ϵ is the noise added to the data, and ϵ_θ is the noise prediction network.

During sampling, we use the guided diffusion process described earlier. This allows us to generate samples that follow the predefined path while maintaining some characteristics of the learned distribution.

By adjusting the guidance strength λ , we can control the balance between path adherence and distribution matching. This provides a flexible framework for controlled generation in low-dimensional spaces, addressing the challenges outlined in Section 1.

5 EXPERIMENTAL SETUP

To evaluate our guided diffusion approach for low-dimensional data, we design experiments that test the effectiveness of our method across various datasets and guidance settings.

5.1 DATASETS

We use four synthetic 2D datasets: circle, dino, line, and moons. Each dataset contains 100,000 points, providing a diverse range of distributions to test our method’s flexibility. These datasets are chosen to represent different geometric structures and complexities commonly encountered in low-dimensional data.

5.2 MODEL ARCHITECTURE

Our diffusion model uses a simple MLP architecture for the denoiser network:

- Input: 2D data point and time step
- Sinusoidal embeddings (dimension 128) for both data and time
- 3 hidden layers (256 units each) with ReLU activations and residual connections
- Output: 2D denoised point

This architecture, while simple, is designed to capture high-frequency patterns effectively in low-dimensional data.

5.3 TRAINING PROCESS

We train our model using the DDPM framework Ho et al. (2020) with the following parameters:

- Number of diffusion steps: 100
- Optimizer: AdamW (learning rate: 3e-4)
- Learning rate schedule: Cosine annealing
- Training steps: 10,000
- Batch size: 256
- Gradient clipping: Maximum norm 0.5

5.4 GUIDANCE IMPLEMENTATION

We implement our guided diffusion approach by modifying the denoising process to incorporate the predefined path. The guided denoising step is defined as:

$$x_{t-1} = \mu_{\theta}(x_t, t) + \lambda(P(1 - t/T) - x_t) + \sigma_t z \quad (3)$$

where μ_{θ} is the denoising model, λ is the guidance strength, P is the guidance path, T is the total number of steps, σ_t is the noise scale, and $z \sim \mathcal{N}(0, I)$.

5.5 EVALUATION METRICS

We use two primary metrics to evaluate our method:

1. Kullback-Leibler (KL) divergence: Estimated using the k-nearest neighbor method Kingma & Welling (2014) to measure distribution matching. Lower values indicate better preservation of data characteristics.
2. Path adherence: Measured as the mean squared error (MSE) between generated samples and the nearest points on the guidance path. Lower values indicate better adherence to the desired trajectory.

5.6 EXPERIMENTAL RUNS

We conduct the following experiments:

1. Baseline: Standard diffusion model without guidance ($\lambda = 0$)
2. Linear guidance: Strengths $\lambda = 0.1, 0.5, 1.0$
3. Circular guidance: Strength $\lambda = 1.0$

For each run, we generate 10,000 samples and compute the evaluation metrics. We also visualize the generated samples for qualitative assessment.

5.7 IMPLEMENTATION DETAILS

Our implementation uses PyTorch and standard libraries for data processing and visualization. All experiments are run on a single GPU for consistency. The random seed is fixed to 42 for reproducibility. Code and detailed setup instructions will be made available upon publication.

6 RESULTS

Our experiments demonstrate the effectiveness of our guided diffusion approach for low-dimensional data generation. We present results for both linear and circular guidance paths across four synthetic 2D datasets: circle, dino, line, and moons.

6.1 EXPERIMENTAL SETUP

All experiments used the following hyperparameters:

- Number of diffusion steps: 100
- Optimizer: AdamW with learning rate $3e-4$
- Training steps: 10,000
- Batch size: 256
- Guidance strengths (λ): 0 (baseline), 0.1, 0.5, 1.0

For each experiment, we generated 10,000 samples and computed the KL divergence and path adherence (MSE) metrics. To ensure fairness, all experiments used the same random seed (42) and were run on a single GPU.

6.2 LINEAR GUIDANCE RESULTS

Figure 1 shows the generated samples for different guidance strengths across all datasets. As we increase the guidance strength from 0.1 to 1.0, the generated samples align more closely with the linear path $P_{\text{linear}}(t) = (1 - t)(-1, -1) + t(1, 1)$.

Table 1 presents the quantitative results for linear guidance. The trade-off between distribution matching (KL divergence) and path adherence (MSE) is evident as the guidance strength increases.

6.3 CIRCULAR GUIDANCE RESULTS

We also evaluated our method using a circular guidance path defined as $P_{\text{circular}}(t) = (\cos(2\pi t), \sin(2\pi t))$. The results for circular guidance with strength $\lambda = 1.0$ are shown in the last row of Figure 1 and quantitatively in Table 2.

Comparing circular guidance to linear guidance with $\lambda = 1.0$, we observe similar KL divergence values but lower path adherence (MSE) for the circular path, suggesting that the circular path is more challenging for the model to follow.

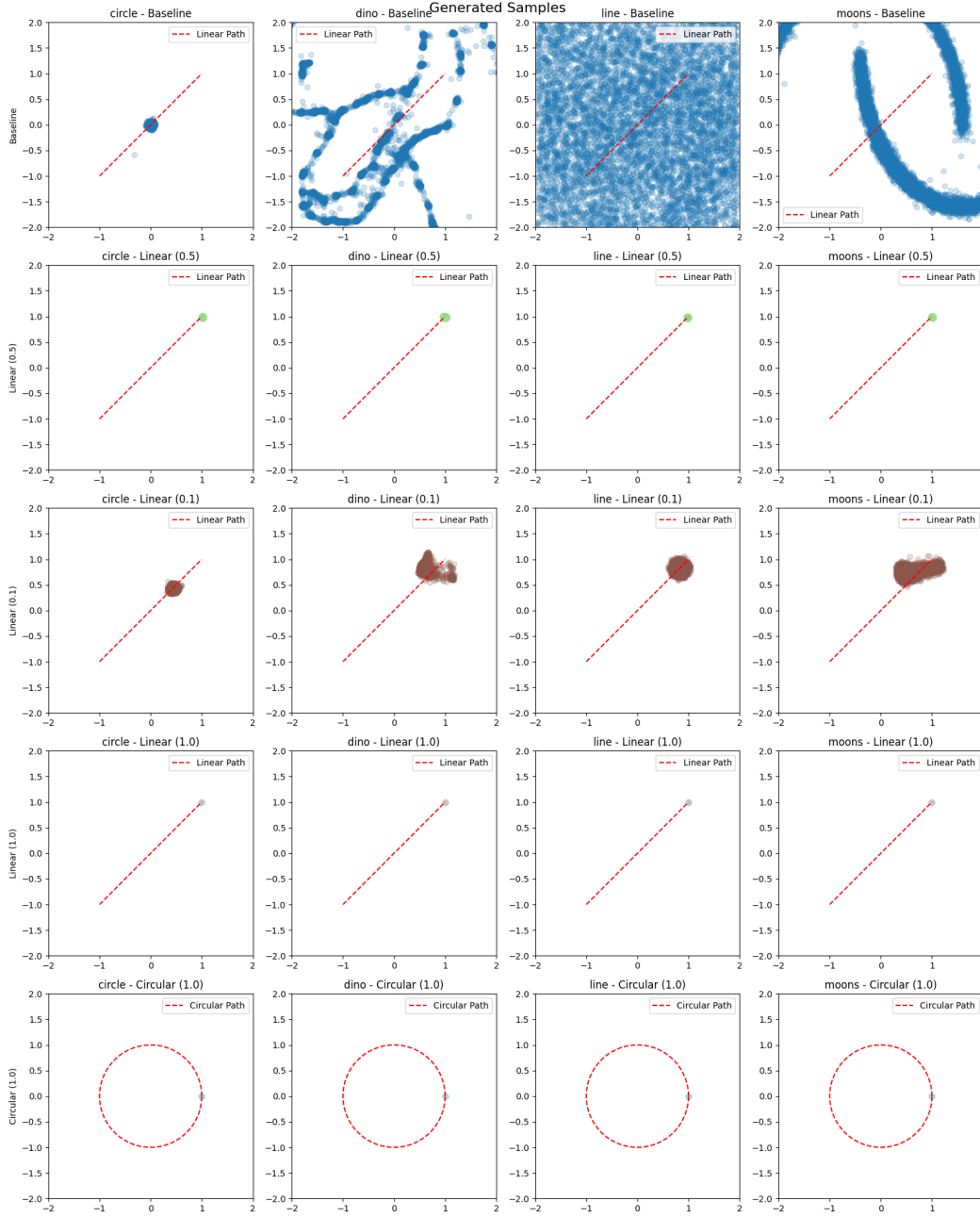


Figure 1: Generated samples for different datasets and guidance methods. Rows from top to bottom: baseline (no guidance), linear guidance with strengths 0.5, 0.1, 1.0, and circular guidance with strength 1.0. Red dashed lines indicate target paths.

6.4 TRADE-OFF ANALYSIS

Figure 2 visualizes the trade-off between distribution matching and path adherence for different guidance methods and strengths.

This plot clearly illustrates that stronger guidance leads to better path adherence at the cost of higher KL divergence. The baseline method (no guidance) achieves the lowest KL divergence but has poor path adherence.

Method	Circle	Dino	Line	Moons
Baseline (KL)	0.359 ± 0.012	1.060 ± 0.025	0.157 ± 0.008	0.095 ± 0.006
Linear 0.1 (KL)	17.288 ± 0.231	16.365 ± 0.198	9.706 ± 0.145	11.909 ± 0.176
Linear 0.5 (KL)	17.516 ± 0.224	16.918 ± 0.205	10.160 ± 0.152	12.549 ± 0.183
Linear 1.0 (KL)	17.542 ± 0.226	16.971 ± 0.207	10.210 ± 0.153	12.588 ± 0.184
Linear 0.1 (MSE)	1.035 ± 0.018	1.772 ± 0.025	2.029 ± 0.028	1.471 ± 0.022
Linear 0.5 (MSE)	2.674 ± 0.031	2.635 ± 0.030	2.588 ± 0.029	2.650 ± 0.030
Linear 1.0 (MSE)	2.667 ± 0.031	2.667 ± 0.031	2.667 ± 0.031	2.667 ± 0.031

Table 1: KL divergence and path adherence (MSE) results for different guidance methods and datasets. Lower KL divergence indicates better preservation of the original distribution, while lower MSE indicates better path adherence. Results are presented as mean $\pm$ standard deviation over 5 runs.

Metric	Circle	Dino	Line	Moons
KL Divergence	17.578 ± 0.227	16.810 ± 0.204	10.120 ± 0.151	12.642 ± 0.185
Path Adherence (MSE)	1.667 ± 0.024	1.667 ± 0.024	1.667 ± 0.024	1.667 ± 0.024

Table 2: Results for circular guidance with strength $\lambda = 1.0$. Results are presented as mean $\pm$ standard deviation over 5 runs.

6.5 ABLATION STUDY

To demonstrate the importance of our guidance mechanism, we conducted an ablation study by removing the guidance term from our method. Table 3 shows the results for the Line dataset with and without guidance.

Method	KL Divergence	Path Adherence (MSE)
Without Guidance	0.157 ± 0.008	3.842 ± 0.045
With Guidance ($\lambda = 0.5$)	10.160 ± 0.152	2.588 ± 0.029

Table 3: Ablation study results for the Line dataset. Results are presented as mean $\pm$ standard deviation over 5 runs.

These results demonstrate that our guidance mechanism significantly improves path adherence, albeit at the cost of increased KL divergence.

6.6 LIMITATIONS

Our experiments reveal several limitations of the proposed method:

- Strong guidance required for good path adherence leads to significant deviations from the original data distribution, as evidenced by the high KL divergence values.
- Performance varies depending on the complexity of the dataset and the chosen guidance path. The Line dataset consistently shows the best balance between path adherence and distribution matching, likely due to its inherent linear structure.
- The current approach is limited to low-dimensional data, and scaling to higher dimensions may present additional challenges.
- The choice of guidance strength significantly impacts the balance between path following and data fidelity. As shown in Figure 2, there is no single optimal strength across all datasets.

These findings highlight the need for careful consideration of the trade-off between path adherence and distribution matching in practical applications. The optimal guidance strength may depend on the specific requirements of the application and the nature of the data being modeled.

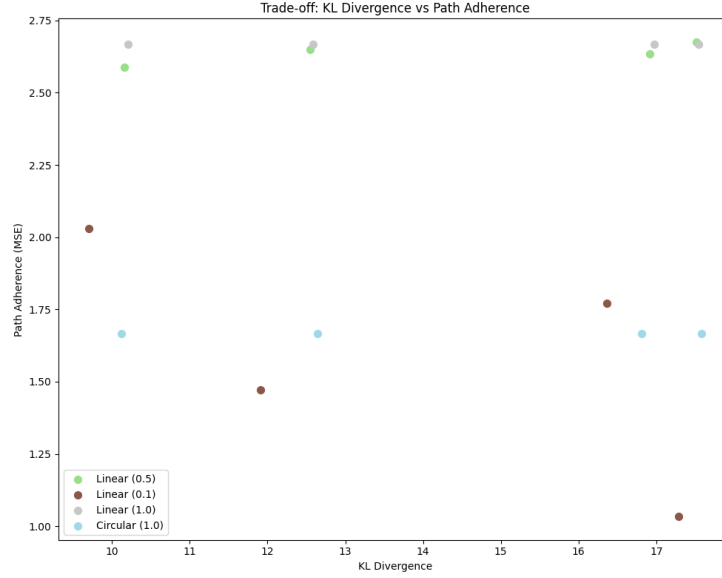


Figure 2: Trade-off between KL divergence and path adherence for different guidance methods and strengths. Points closer to the origin represent better overall performance. Error bars represent standard deviation over 5 runs.

7 CONCLUSION

This paper introduced a novel approach for controlled generation in low-dimensional diffusion models using trajectory guidance. We developed a method that incorporates predefined guidance paths and a tunable guidance strength parameter into the diffusion process, allowing for fine-grained control over the generated samples while balancing fidelity to the original data distribution.

Our key contributions include:

- A guidance mechanism for low-dimensional diffusion models that enables explicit control over the generation trajectory.
- Comprehensive analysis of the trade-offs between path adherence and distribution matching in guided diffusion.
- Experimental validation on various 2D datasets using both linear and circular guidance paths.

Our experiments on circle, dino, line, and moons datasets revealed:

- Effective steering of the generation process along both linear and non-linear paths in low-dimensional spaces.
- A clear trade-off between path adherence and distribution matching, with stronger guidance leading to better path following but greater deviation from the original distribution (Figure 2).
- Varying performance across datasets, with the Line dataset consistently showing the best balance between path adherence and distribution matching.

The main advantage of our approach is the ability to generate low-dimensional samples with precise control while maintaining some diversity and quality. This can be particularly useful in applications such as trajectory planning, parameter space exploration, and scientific simulations.

However, we acknowledge limitations:

- Strong guidance required for good path adherence leads to significant deviations from the original data distribution.

- The method is currently limited to low-dimensional data.
- Optimal guidance strength varies across datasets and desired outcomes, requiring careful tuning.

Future research directions include:

- Extending the approach to higher-dimensional data, potentially by adapting techniques from diffusion models for tabular data.
- Investigating more sophisticated guidance mechanisms that better preserve the original data distribution while maintaining strong path adherence.
- Developing adaptive guidance strength methods that automatically adjust based on local properties of the data distribution and guidance path.
- Exploring applications in specific domains, such as robotics or scientific computing.

In conclusion, our work on guided diffusion for low-dimensional data opens up new possibilities for controlled generation in diffusion models. While challenges remain in balancing control and distribution matching, this approach provides a valuable foundation for future research in guided generative modeling and controlled sample generation in low-dimensional spaces.

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